Research Project

Prompt: Education inequality in Taiwan: How does it impact the community and how could we solve it

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Part 1 AI-generated essay

<u>Part 1.1 ChatGPT generated essay (Word Count: 224)</u>

Education inequality in Taiwan remains a significant concern, particularly between urban and rural regions. A 2022 survey by the Child Welfare League Foundation revealed that nearly 70% of students in rural areas lacked devices for online education, exacerbating disparities during the COVID-19 pandemic. (TAIPEI TIMES)

This urban-rural divide has profound implications for the community. Students in rural schools often encounter inadequate infrastructure, limited extracurricular activities, and a shortage of qualified teachers. Such conditions hinder social mobility and perpetuate economic disparities, as these students face challenges in accessing higher education and competitive employment opportunities.

To address these challenges, the Taiwanese government has implemented several initiatives. Since 2016, efforts have included raising childrearing allowances, expanding affordable education and care services, reducing student-teacher ratios, and upgrading campus environments at the high school level and below. Additionally, programs aimed at supporting rural and economically disadvantaged students have been promoted to achieve educational equality. (ENGLISH PORTAL OF THE EXECUTIVE YUAN)

Non-governmental organizations also play a crucial role. For instance, Teach for Taiwan

mobilizes young educators to serve in rural communities, striving to bridge educational gaps and empower students through quality teaching. (TAIWAN PANORAMA)

A comprehensive approach involving government policies, community engagement, and technological integration is essential to mitigate education inequality in Taiwan. By ensuring equitable access to resources and opportunities, Taiwan can foster a more inclusive and prosperous society.

Part 1.2 Reflect on the AI-generated essay (Word Count: 200)

For Part 1, I logged in to ChatGPT with my Google account and used it to generate the essay. ChatGPT is easy to operate and does not require any complicated account registration process. Only by entering my prompt: “based on the prompt: Education inequality in Taiwan: How does it impact the community and how could we solve it?, generate a 200 word essay on this topic”, I soon got a well-written essay. However, since I wanted the AI generator to include some sources that make the essay look more credible, I later inserted my second prompt to generate the essay, which was “can you include some source or examples to increase the credibility, still around 200 words”.

With the research I have done this semester, I would say that the second essay ChatGPT generated based on the more specific prompt is more complete and persuasive. The second essay includes not only research data and factual real-life examples but also provides a

reference list at the end of the response so readers can easily refer to it. Overall, the way the generator accurately understood the prompt and generated a corresponding and well-written essay in only a few seconds is really impressive.

Part 2 Your Findings (Word Count: 800)

Inequality, according to the Oxford Dictionary, means "Unequal treatment of people; unfairness." (*Inequality, n. Meanings, Etymology and More | Oxford English Dictionary*, n.d.). In Taiwan, education inequality in recent years has been a rising issue due to the increasing urban-rural gap. To solve this issue, the government has been improving education-related policies in response to the changing situations, meanwhile, more social groups joined the line to create innovative ways, to find and even develop suitable teaching platforms to connect rural areas with more resources, and some also recruited passionate volunteers to improve rural environment in person. With support from all around, the children in rural areas seem to gradually see a glimmer of hope for change.

Compared to urban areas, where younger generations gather for well-paid salaries and opportunities, people living in rural areas are mostly elderly and can only do easy farming to support their family's living. The increasing wage gap between cities caused by the outmigration of the working-age population and the inability of rural governments to develop and improve facilities, including education institutions, are both now seen as the main reasons that result in education inequality nationwide.

Chih-Cheng and Yao, who refer to the analysis of researcher Fu on Taiwan education, mentioned: “Fu further contends that students from low SES families are easily sacrificed in the national obsession with education.” (Chih-Cheng & Yao, 2009, page 291). Furthermore, they found a positive correlation between students’ high SES family backgrounds and their attendance at better institutions. Indeed, in many real-life cases, children from relatively low family socioeconomic status (SES) are mostly from poor areas and commonly seen dropping out of school when the 9-year compulsory education is over. Teenagers from broken environments stop pursuing higher education to work to support their families. Such inequality from birth gradually exploited the children’s chance of receiving a deserved education and caused the education inequality dilemma.

Additionally, based on what ChatGPT organized according to the prompt, “A 2022 survey by the Child Welfare League Foundation revealed that nearly 70% of students in rural areas lacked devices for online education, exacerbating disparities during the COVID-19 pandemic.” (*Chatgpt.Com*, 2025). The lack and under-distribution of advanced technologies in rural areas stopped children from receiving compulsory education, further exacerbating the educational gap in underprivileged areas.

To deal with the educational inequality between urban and rural areas, the Ministry of Education in Taiwan released a series of policies to approach the problem in 2023, and one significant change was to close the tuition fee gap. The Executive Yuan passed a NT$21.9

billion (US$706.5 million) bill plan to subsidize tuition for students from underprivileged cities (Ministry of Education, 2011). The subsidies not only waive tuition fees for senior and vocational school students, provide fee waivers for underprivileged students to pursue education and purchase required materials, but also lower the standard for students in need to easily apply for student loans (Ministry of Education, 2011). By closing the tuition gap, the Ministry of Education improves underprivileged students' education rights and encourages them to pursue higher education to be equipped with more knowledge and become more competitive.

Meanwhile, NGO groups in Taiwan were also enhancing the education ecosystem by taking real actions. Teach for Taiwan, similar to Teach for America and also known as TFT, was established by An-ting Liu in 2013. In the past 12 years, TFT has collaborated with 94 local schools in 9 rural cities in Taiwan. To provide high-standard experimental education, "TFT looks not only for teaching ability, but also problem-solving skills, self-awareness, the ability to deal with frustration, communication skills, and leadership." (Chen Chun-fang, n.d.). Furthermore, instead of teaching in traditional ways, TFT created its own "grading system". As Sung Wan Jung, a former TFT teacher said about the TFT missions in the interview: "Exams aren't about defining a child by their score, but about understanding how much they have learned and where we need to work harder." (Chen Chun-fang, n.d.). By innovatively cultivating underprivileged students, TFT not only develops their soft skills but

also lets them know that even a child from a rural area could make a big difference.

As Moran and Mallman discussed in their article regarding social cohesion in rural Australia, '"Belonging" implies shared values, consensus, commitment and collective identity (feeling oneself to be part of a shared community), while feelings of isolation among individuals and groups threaten social cohesion."(Moran & Mallman, 2019, page 192). In the same country, education inequality excludes students in rural areas from receiving better education. To cease the vicious cycle, both governments and social groups have worked hard to reduce the source gap between cities. Even if there is no perfect solution and the issue cannot be solved instantly, as long as social reform is ongoing, we should believe the communities will eventually be inclusive and justice.

Part 3 Reflective Essay on the Research Process (Word Count: 666)

In the beginning, I decided to research the inequality I discovered in my community and set it as my research topic. However, as we keep finding sources and leaving feedback for the peer review, I noticed that it seems like everyone discusses a clear focus instead of a vast concept for their research paper. Hence, I decided to enhance my research topic and narrow it down to discuss only education inequality in my community. Since I am from Taiwan, considering that most sources that fits my research are in Mandarin, I have to filter and choose those sources that provides English version. In addition, the sources I find should also meet the requirement of the 6 source types provided. Eventually, lost in the Google search, I

decided to get back to using the OU library. As I keep familiarizing the webpage, I found the OU database useful and powerful since I can filter for certain source types with keywords that are related to my research topic.

After browsing all potential sources through the OU library website, I figured that some sources such as primary sources and suitable websites were hard to find. Luckily, when I decided to use my favorite AI ChatGPT to finish the Part 1.1 essay, I noticed that ChatGPT has now improved to generate a reference list for all sources used in answering the prompt. Therefore, by checking the sources ChatGPT collected one by one, I finally collected all the source types I needed for the research paper. After finishing the last time checking sources, I eventually decided to eliminate those that provided too broad information, even if they looked promising.

After the sources were collected, I needed to pull it all together to write my essay. To me, Part 1 was the easiest part to finish. By providing a more specific prompt, ChatGPT gave me an answer that was way beyond my expectations, and it only saved me from finding suitable sources. While for Part 2, it was all about my research journey and I had to write a persuasive essay based on the sources I found. Based on multiple writing experiences, I know that issues must happen that may change my writing perspectives. Without surprise, I soon ran into a big issue of exceeding word limits, hence I needed to eliminate some ideas that I was about to mention, and I should also again give up using certain sources. I was quite

frustrated when it came to the dilemma of choosing “better ideas and sources”. But to balance the source type and meet the requirements, I decided to eliminate those sources with repeated source types. Eventually, I referred to six sources from six source types in my essay.

Overall, I would say the process of writing the research paper was fun but also a bit hard. The hardship was about developing more specific research skills to get better sources and apply them in a new citation format with different details. However, when everything is done, looking back, I think I have indeed become a better researcher. Through the research, I learned to use more appropriate keywords to look up sources, I also learned to balance the helpful sources based on the given accessing criteria.

Though I still have many advanced research techniques to learn, and sometimes missing details when it comes to citing sources, at least I took the challenge and tried my best to finish the assignment, hence I feel proud of myself. I also feel lucky to have AI to be my writing partners, though many argue that AI may weaken human creativity, from my perspective, if using it correctly and inputting the appropriate prompt, it could really change my process moving forward in a more efficient way. I would not change any process even if I had another chance since I know “No pain, no gain.”. Without making mistakes, I would never know where I could improve, hence I appreciate every experience I had for this research project.

References

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